ISRAEL E A IGREJA

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ISRAEL E IGREJA

por GEORGE ELDON LADD

George Eldon Ladd, "Israel e a Igreja", O Trimestral Evangélico 36.4 (outubro de 1964): 206-214.

DR. LADD, que ocupa a cadeira de História do Novo Testamento e Teologia Bíblica no Seminário Teológico Fuller, Pasadena, Califórnia, é bem conhecido pelos leitores do THE EVANGELICAL QUARTERLY. Este estudo de Israel e da Igreja está intimamente relacionado com outros assuntos sobre os quais ele já escreveu para nós. E vem dentro da área de seus interesses especiais. Se alguns leitores não se importam com suas referências ao Milênio na quarta e quinta seções deste artigo, eles podem substituir essa palavra pelas palavras paulinas "eras que virão" (Ef. 2: 7) em que Deus aperfeiçoará essa reconciliação cósmica da qual a Igreja é seu modelo atual.

O problema teológico da relação de Israel com a igreja recebeu respostas radicalmente diversas. Por um lado, há um tipo de teologia da aliança que insiste que a igreja é o Israel espiritual no sentido mais completo da palavra. Como Israel rejeitou seu Messias, Deus rejeitou Israel. O Reino foi tirado de Israel e "dado a uma nação que produz os seus frutos" (Mt 21: 43). Esse "sacerdócio real", esta "nação santa", este "povo de Deus" é a Igreja (I Pet. 2: 9). A Igreja é, portanto, o Israel espiritual, o verdadeiro povo de Deus. Quando os judeus em Roma rejeitaram o evangelho, Paulo disse: " Seja conhecido então que esta salvação de Deus foi enviada para os gentios; eles ouvirão" (Atos 28: 28). Porque Israel rejeitou seu Messias, "a ira de Deus finalmente caiu sobre eles" (l Ts. 2: 16). A Igreja é agora o "Israel de Deus" (Gl. 6: 16). O Israel espiritual tomou o lugar do Israel literal. O Antigo Testamento promete que o Israel literal deve ser interpretado em termos das bênçãos espirituais desfrutadas pela Igreja. Portanto, não há necessidade de um Reino Milenal. Os israelitas serão salvos apenas quando crerem em Cristo e entrarem na Igreja.

No extremo oposto está a interpretação dispensacionalista que insiste que Israel e a Igreja são dois povos separados que não podem ser misturados e não devem ser confundidos. Na verdade, Deus tem dois programas diferentes que Ele está realizando na história: um com Israel e outro com a Igreja. Os programas teocráticos de Deus com Israel foram interrompidos quando Israel rejeitou Cristo. Deus, portanto, se afastou de Israel para realizar seu propósito redentor na Igreja. Quando este propósito for cumprido, Deus retomará suas relações com Israel.

O Milênio evidenciará a retomada deste propósito teocrático e Israel será restaurado como uma nação, em sua terra da Palestina, com uma monarquia reconstituída, e governará sobre as nações da Terra em nome de seu Deus. Seu Rei será o prometido Messias Davídico que se sentará ao trono literal de Davi e governará o mundo de Jerusalém. A adoração do templo de

Israel e a ordem sacerdotal dos tempos do Antigo Testamento, incluindo o sistema de sacrifício, serão restaurados. Todas as promessas do Antigo Testamento serão cumpridas em termos literais. O Milênio, em outras palavras, será um renascimento ou renovação da ordem do Antigo Testamento. A era da igreja é um parêntese no programa de Deus para Israel e não deve ser confundida com ela. Para alguns teólogos dispensacionais, um dos maiores perigos para compreender a interpretação bíblica é um hermenêutica "espiritualizante" que espiritualiza às promessas da igreja que foram feitas a Israel. Na verdade, às vezes a hermenêutica literalista é testada pela ortodoxia[1].

Talvez, como é frequentemente o caso, a solução bíblica para o problema esteja entre os dois extremos. Nós tentaremos resolver o problema por uma série de cinco proposições.

I

Primeiro em algum sentido real, a Igreja tomou o lugar em Israel e deve ser chamada de Israel "espiritual". Este "espiritualização" de Israel começou no Antigo Testamento. Paulo deixa isso claro. Nem todos os descendentes de Abraão fisicamente são filhos de Abraão espiritualmente. "Nem todos são filhos de Abraão porque são seus descendentes" (Rm 9: 7). "Não são os filhos do carne que são filhos de Deus, mas os filhos da promessa são contados como descendentes" (Rm 9: 8). A semente física não é a verdadeira semente. O Israel literal não é o Israel espiritual. O Israel espiritual, a semente espiritual, consiste apenas daqueles dentro da semente física que são os filhos da promessa. As escrituras limitam a verdadeira semente espiritual de Abraão a uma linha estreita entre os descendentes físicos.

Não só a semente espiritual de Abraão se limita a um pequeno grupo dentro da semente literal, como também é estendida a igreja. Paulo deixa isso claro em Romanos 4: 16, 18. Deus prometeu a Abraão que sua semente deveria ser tão inumerável quanto as estrelas; Paulo aplica essa promessa à Igreja. Esta promessa à semente de Abraão, diz Paulo, foi dada "não apenas aos adeptos da lei (a semente literal), mas também àqueles que compartilham a fé de Abraão". (A semente espiritual) (Rom 4:16). "Se você é de Cristo, então você é descendente de Abraão, herdeiros segundo a promessa" (Gálatas 3: 29). Assim, Abraão é "o pai de todos nós", que tem a mesma fé justificativa que Abraão tinha (Rom. 4: 16). Abraão foi feito "o pai de todos os que creem sem serem circuncidados" (Rom. 4: 11). É impossível a linguagem afirmar com mais clareza que a semente espiritual de Abraão, seus verdadeiros filhos espirituais, são os homens

[1] Veja John F. Walvoord, O Reino Do Milênio (Durham Publishing Co., Findlay, Ohio, 1959), pp. 71 f., 124.

que creem na fé no Senhor Jesus Cristo - a Igreja. Assim, a Igreja em um sentido real é o Israel espiritual. Isso é igualmente claro em Romanos 2: 28-29: " Porque não é judeu quem o é apenas exteriormente, nem é circuncisão a que é somente na carne. Porém judeu é aquele que o é interiormente, e circuncisão, a que é do coração, no espírito, não segundo a letra, e cujo louvor não procede dos homens, mas de Deus. " A versão King James dá uma impressão diferente ao traduzir "no espírito" e "na letra". Essas frases não têm referência ao Espírito Santo. Nem "no espírito" é uma construção paralela ao "do coração". Elas se referem a duas maneiras de interpretar o ensino do Antigo Testamento sobre a circuncisão, como indica o RSV. O grego, traduzido literalmente, diz: "circuncisão (é) de coração, em espírito, não em letra". "Na carta" significa uma interpretação literal da circuncisão. Isso é feito cortando um pedaço de carne do corpo, como fizeram os judeus sob a ordem do Antigo Testamento, para se tornar o povo literal de Deus. "Em espírito" significa uma interpretação espiritual da circuncisão. Isso é feito pelo Espírito Santo, fazendo uma mudança no coração, para que nos tornemos o povo espiritual de Deus - a verdadeira semente - o verdadeiro Israel. Que ninguém sugira que é errado interpretar o Antigo Testamento "espiritualmente"; o Novo Testamento faz exatamente isso reinterpretando a circuncisão em termos espirituais e aplicando-a à experiência cristã. Nossa primeira proposição está agora estabelecida: os crentes são os verdadeiros filhos de Abraão, a verdadeira semente, a circuncisão espiritual - o Israel espiritual.

II

Nossa segunda proposição é a seguinte: O Novo Testamento recebe promessas que no Antigo Testamento eram dirigidas ao Israel literal e as aplica "espiritualmente" à Igreja.

Vamos usar duas provas. O profeta Oséias prediz a rejeição do Israel literal por causa de seu pecado. Oséias foi instruído por Deus a encenar uma parábola para ilustrar o relacionamento de Deus com Israel. Ele foi ordenado a nomear um de seus filhos "Lo-ruhamah", que significa " Não se Teve Misericórdia". A razão para isto é a seguinte: Deus disse: "porque não terei mais piedade da casa de Israel" (1: 6). Outro filho Oséias deveria nomear "Lo-ammi", que significa "não é meu povo". O significado disso é: "pois você não é meu povo e eu não sou seu Deus" (1: 9). Por essa parábola figurada, Oséias deveria mostrar a Israel que Deus o havia rejeitado. No entanto, Oséias prevê uma restauração do Israel literal. Deus fará uma nova aliança com Israel (2: 18) e comprometerá Israel a si mesmo para sempre (2: 19). " E semeá-la-ei para mim na terra e compadecer-me-ei de Lo-Ruama; e a Lo-Ami direi: Tu és meu povo! E ele dirá: Tu és o meu Deus!" (2: 23). Israel literal que foi rejeitado deve ser restaurado.

O Novo Testamento aplica a profecia ao Israel espiritual - a Igreja. Falando desse novo povo que consiste não apenas dos judeus, mas também dos gentios, Paulo diz: "Como de fato ele diz em Oséias: 'Aqueles que não eram meu povo, chamarei de" meu povo ", e ela que não era amada, chamarei "minha amada", (Rm 9: 25). Novamente, referindo-se a Oséias 1: 9, que citamos, Paulo acrescenta: "E no mesmo lugar em que lhes foi dito: Você não é meu povo", eles serão chamados 'filhos do Deus vivo' "(Rm 9: 26). Como podemos evitar a conclusão de que Paulo aqui quer dizer que a promessa da restauração do Israel literal é cumprida na Igreja?

Uma segunda prova. Joel, como Oséias, prevê a restauração do Israel literal. "Sabereis que estou no meio de Israel e que eu, o Senhor, sou o teu Deus e não há mais nada. E o meu povo nunca mais será envergonhado" (Jl 2, 27). A seguir, segue a maravilhosa profecia do derramamento do Espírito Santo sobre toda a carne (2: 28-29). Esta é claramente uma promessa ao Israel literal, pois a profecia continua: "Pois eis que naqueles dias e naquele tempo, quando eu restauro as fortunas de Judá e Jerusalém..." (3: 1). No entanto, no dia de Pentecostes, quando o Espírito Santo foi dado à Igreja, Pedro, inspirado, disse: "Foi o que foi dito pelo profeta Joel" (Atos 2: 16). Um prolongamento dado ao Israel literal é cumprido ao Israel espiritual - a Igreja.

III

A Antiga Aliança, feita com Israel literal, incluía os sacrifícios sangrentos de touros e bodes. Estes, no entanto, não podiam tirar os pecados (Hb 10: 4). Eles eram apenas tipos e sombras da realidade incorporada na morte de Cristo (Hb 10: 1). No entanto, agora que a realidade chegou, as sombras passaram (Hb 10: 2). Cristo tornou-se o mediador de uma aliança melhor (Hb 8: 6). A antiga aliança mosaica, com seus sacrifícios de animais, não era adequada para cumprir o propósito redentor de Deus. Se tivesse sido, não haveria necessidade de um segundo convênio (8: 7). No entanto, Deus prometeu por meio de Jeremias (31: 31-34) uma nova aliança quando Deus escreveria Sua lei dentro do coração, quando Ele efetuaria o perdão dos pecados. Esta é a nova aliança no sangue de Cristo, "derramada por muitos pelo perdão dos pecados" (Mt 26: 28). Como essa nova aliança foi estabelecida, a antiga aliança é substituída pela nova aliança. "Ao falar de uma nova aliança, ele trata a primeira como obsoleta. E o que está se tornando obsoleto e envelhecendo está pronto para desaparecer" (Hb 8: 13). A ordem do Antigo Testamento, com seu sistema de sacrifícios de animais, mesmo que ainda existisse quando os Hebreus foram escritos, foi substituída pela nova aliança em Cristo; e a ordem do templo realmente faleceu logo após a escrita de Hebreus, quando Jerusalém e o templo foram destruídos em 70 d.C. A mensagem de toda a Epístola aos Hebreus é que todas essas instituições e sacrifícios pertencem à era dos tipos e as sombras se foram, porque foram cumpridas pelas realidades de Cristo.

IV

Nossa quarta proposição é a seguinte: Embora a Igreja seja o Israel espiritual, o Novo Testamento ensina que o Israel literal ainda está para ser salvo. Paulo estava muito preocupado com o destino de Israel e o aparente fracasso das promessas de Deus. No entanto, o fato de Israel rejeitar seu Messias e falhar em chegar à fé não significa que as promessas de Deus e a Palavra de Deus falharam (Rom. 9: 6). As promessas de Deus são cumpridas na verdadeira semente (espiritual) de Abraão (Rom. 9: 7 e seguintes). O verdadeiro povo de Deus, cuja salvação foi predita em Oséias 2: 23 e 1: 10, consiste não no Israel literal, mas naqueles "a quem ele chamou, não somente dos judeus, mas também dos gentios" (Rom. 9: 24). O Israel literal tropeçou na rocha de escândalo (Rom. 9:33). Cristo cumpriu toda a intenção e o propósito da Lei e, assim, encerrou a dispensação da Lei, tendo introduzido a dispensação da justiça pela fé (Rm 10: 4). Israel não entrou nessa fé, e em desobediência e teimosia se recusou a responder ao apelo gracioso de Deus (Rm 10: 21).

No entanto, isso não significa que Deus finalmente rejeitou seu povo (Rm 11: 1). Há, antes de tudo, um remanescente do Israel literal que creu em Cristo (11: 5). O resto de Israel ficou cego (Il: 7). No entanto, o objetivo de sua cegueira não é sua queda; por causa de sua queda, a salvação chegou aos gentios (11: 11). Então, Paulo faz uma declaração chave: “Agora, se a transgressão deles significa riquezas para o mundo, e se o fracasso deles significa riquezas, para os gentios, quanto mais sua inclusão completa significa!” (11: 12).

Nesta declaração está incorporada a teologia de Paulo da futura salvação de Israel. Se a queda de Israel trouxe salvação aos gentios, em que medida maior a salvação chegará ao mundo gentio se a "plenitude", isto é, a salvação completa do Israel literal, entrar? Israel foi o instrumento escolhido por Deus para trazer salvação ao mundo. Este foi o coração da promessa feita a Abraão. Ele deveria ser o pai de muitas nações, e nele todas as famílias da Terra seriam abençoadas (Gênesis 12: 1-3; 17: 6). Romanos 4: 17-18 e Gálatas 3: 8 provam que essa promessa deve ser interpretada não apenas literalmente da semente física de Abraão, mas que a verdade mais profunda é encontrada na interpretação espiritual que a aplica aos crentes em Cristo - a Igreja. É por isso que Cristo veio ao mundo como israelita. A rejeição de Israel ao seu Messias e sua queda subsequente não foram um mero acidente da história, mas os meios usados por Deus para trazer salvação aos gentios. Mas este não é o último capítulo da história. A era da Igreja como a conhecemos não é o fim. Duas coisas ainda precisam acontecer: a plenitude do Israel literal deve entrar, e por sua salvação maiores riquezas serão trazidas ao mundo gentio.

Paulo ainda desenvolve essa verdade nos seguintes versículos. Israel literal ainda é o povo escolhido. Ela ainda é o objeto especial do cuidado de Deus e ainda será o instrumento da salvação. Isto é afirmado em Romanos 11: 15-16. As primícias de Israel (os patriarcas) eram sagradas - isto é, os objetos da eleição e dos cuidados de Deus; e todo a raiz (Israel como povo) também é santo. Se a raiz da árvore é santa, a árvore inteira também é. O povo de Israel continua sendo um povo "santo" - um povo que Deus designou para seu propósito redentor no mundo. Esse objetivo futuro é indicado nas seguintes palavras: "Pois se a rejeição deles significa a reconciliação do mundo, o que significa a aceitação deles senão a vida dentre os mortos?" (v. 15). Aqui está um duplo contraste: a atual rejeição de Israel por causa da incredulidade é contrastada com um futuro recebimento de Israel na crença. O outro contraste é ainda mais significativo. A atual rejeição de Israel incrédulo significa que a mensagem da reconciliação se espalhou por todo o mundo; A futura restauração de Israel significará muito mais do que isso - um estado de bem-aventurança que Paulo descreve pela frase "vida dos mortos". A estrutura equilibrada da sentença mostra que essa é uma bênção que sobrevém aos gentios. mundo. O equilíbrio da sentença é a chave para sua interpretação, e o diagrama a seguir ilustra o equilíbrio.

I	II
a. Rejeição presente a Israel.	a. Reconciliação do mundo.
b. Restauração futura de Israel.	b. Vida dos mortos

Israel é citado nas 2 linhas da Parte I; e o mundo gentio é citado nas 2 linhas da Parte II. "A vida dos mortos" (II b) não é um membro paralelo de "Israel" (I b), mas de "mundo" (II a). Está em contraste com Israel (l b). "Vida dos mortos" não se refere à restauração de Israel, mas aos resultados da restauração de Israel no mundo gentio. A futura salvação de Israel resultará em uma nova ordem de bênção e felicidade para o mundo gentio, que é comparada ao surgimento da vida dentre os mortos. Resta no futuro para o mundo um desfrutar da realidade da vida em Cristo que se estende muito além de tudo o que já experimentamos; e isso será realizado através da instrumentalidade da conversão de Israel. Paulo não nos diz aqui quando ou como essa era de bênção ocorrerá; mas acreditamos que isso acontecerá durante o milênio.

Paulo resume toda a questão nos versículos 25-27. Israel agora está endurecido. Os gentios estão agora sendo trazidos. Finalmente "todo o Israel será salvo". "Israel" aqui é Israel literal; e "todo Israel" não precisa significar todo israelita, mas o povo como um todo. Paulo não acrescenta aqui o pensamento de que, através desta salvação do povo de Israel, uma nova onda de vida chegará ao mundo inteiro, pois sua preocupação neste momento é apenas o destino de Israel.

V

Nossa proposição final é a seguinte: Essa futura salvação de Israel deve ocorrer fundamentalmente nos mesmos termos que a salvação dos gentios, a saber, através da fé salvadora em Jesus Cristo como seu Messias crucificado. Em nenhum lugar o Novo Testamento discute como isso deve acontecer. As palavras em Romanos 11: 26, "O libertador virá de Sião, ele banirá a impiedade de Jacó", não se refere necessariamente à Segunda Vinda de Cristo. Esta é uma citação composta de Isaías 59: 20 e 27: 9, nenhuma das quais se refere ao Messias. No que diz respeito à passagem em Romanos 11, a salvação de Israel poderia ocorrer por um grande movimento evangelístico que traria Israel à Igreja. No entanto, o Antigo Testamento constantemente vê a salvação de Israel como uma entidade distinta. Por isso, podemos apenas sugerir que os meios de conversão de Israel podem realmente ser a Segunda Vinda Deus disse através de Zacarias: "E derramarei sobre a casa de Davi e os habitantes de Jerusalém: um espírito de compaixão e súplica, de modo que, quando olharem para aquele a quem traspassaram, lamentarão por ele, como se lamenta por um filho único, e chora amargamente por ele, como se chora por um primogênito "(12: 10). Aparentemente, a aparência de Cristo traspassado convencerá Israel de sua pecaminosidade.

Isso não significa que Israel será salvo em qualquer outro terreno que não seja pela fé em Cristo. Isso sugere que os meios de salvação são incomuns. Saulo de Tarso foi trazido à fé somente por uma visão especial do Cristo glorificado; no entanto, ele foi salvo pela fé como qualquer crente e foi trazido para a igreja cristã. De maneira semelhante, talvez, seja a aparência do Cristo que retornou, que será o meio de convencer Israel de que Jesus era realmente o Messias dela. Nesse caso, eles serão salvos pela fé em Cristo e, no sentido mais amplo da palavra, se tornarão parte da Igreja, mas como um povo distinto. Talvez durante o milênio, veremos pela primeira vez na história da humanidade uma nação verdadeiramente cristã - Israel convertida e trazida à fé em Jesus como seu Messias.

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ISRAEL AND CHURCH

by GEORGE ELDON LADD

George Eldon Ladd, "Israel and the Church," The Evangelical Quarterly 36.4 (Oct. 1964): 206- 214.

DR. LADD: Who occupies the Chair of New Testament History and Biblical Theology in Fuller Theological Seminary, Pasadena, California, is well known to readers of THE EVANGELICAL QUARTERLY. This study of Israel and the Church is closely related to other subjects on which he has already written for us. And comes Within the area of his special interests. If some readers do not care for his references to the Millennium in the fourth and fifth sections of this article, they may replace that word by the Pauline "ages to come" (Eph. 2: 7) in which God will perfect that cosmic reconciliation of which the Church is His present model.

The theological problem of the relationship of Israel to the church has received radically diverse answers. On the one hand is a type of covenantal theology which insists that the church is spiritual Israel in the most exhaustive sense of the word. Because Israel rejected her Messiah, God has rejected Israel. The Kingdom has been taken away from Israel and "given to a nation producing the fruits of It" (Matt. 21: 43). This "royal priesthood", this "holy nation", this "God's own people" is the Church (I Pet. 2: 9). The Church is therefore the spiritual Israel, the true people of God. When the Jews in Rome rejected the gospel, Paul said, "Let it be known to you then that this salvation of God has been sent to the Gentiles; they will listen" (Acts 28: 28). Because Israel rejected her Messiah, "God's wrath has come upon them at last" (l Thess. 2: 16). The Church is now the "Israel of God" (Gal. 6: 16). The spiritual Israel has taken the place of the literal Israel. The Old Testament promises to. the literal Israel must be interpreted in terms of the spiritual blessings enjoyed by the Church. Therefore, there is no need of a Millennial Kingdom. Israelites will be saved only as they believe on Christ and come into the Church.

At the opposite extreme is the dispensationalist interpretation which insists that Israel and the Church are two separate peoples which cannot be mingled and must not be confused. In fact, God has two different programmes which He is carrying out in history: one with Israel and one with the Church. God's theocratic programmes with Israel was interrupted when Israel rejected Christ. God therefore turned away from Israel to accomplish His redemptive purpose in the Church. When this purpose has been fulfilled, God will resume His relations with Israel.

The Millennium will see the resumption of this theocratic purpose and Israel will be restored as a nation, in her land of Palestine, with a reconstituted monarchy, and will rule over the nations of the earth on behalf or her God. Her King will be the promised Davidic Messiah who will sit upon the literal throne of David and rule the world from Jerusalem. Israel's temple worship and priestly order of Old Testament times, including the sacrificial system, will be

restored. All the promises of the Old Testament will be fulfilled in literal terms. The Millennium in other words, will be a revival or renewal of the Old Testament' order. The church age is a parenthesis in God's programme for Israel and must not be confused with it. To some dispensational theologians, one of the greatest dangers to sound Biblical interpretation is a "spiritualizing" hermeneutic which applies spiritually to the church promises which were made to Israel. In fact, a literalistic hermeneutic is sometimes made the test of orthodoxy[1] .

Perhaps, as is often the case, the Biblical solution to the problem lies between the two extremes. We would attempt to solve the problem by a series of five propositions.

I

First in some real sense, the Church has taken the place at Israel and must be called the "spiritual" Israel. This "spiritualizing" of Israel began in the Old Testament. Paul makes this clear. Not all who are descended from Abraham physically are sons of Abraham spiritually. "Not all are children of Abraham because they are his descendants" (Rom. 9: 7). "It is not the children of the flesh who are the children of God, but the children of the promises are reckoned as descendants" (Rom. 9: 8). The physical seed IS not the true seed. The literal Israel is not the spiritual Israel. The spiritual Israel, the spiritual seed, consists only of those within the physical seed who are children of promise. The Scripture limits the true spiritual seed of Abraham to one narrowing line within the physical descendants. Not only is the spiritual seed of Abraham limited to a small group within the literal seed, it is also extended to the Church. Paul makes this clear in Romans 4: 16, 18. God had promised Abraham that his seed should be as innumerable as the stars; Paul applies this promise to the Church. This promise to Abraham's seed, says Paul, was given "not only to the adherents of the law (the literal seed) but also to those who share the faith of Abraham". (the spiritual seed) (Rom 4:16). Therefore, "if you are Christ's, then you are Abraham's offspring, heirs according to promise" (Gal. 3: 29). Thus, Abraham is "the father of us all" who have the same justifying faith which Abraham had (Rom. 4: 16). Abraham has been made "the father of all who believe without being circumcised" (Rom. 4: 11). It is impossible for language to state more clearly that Abraham's spiritual seed, his true spiritual children, are the men of faith-believers in the Lord Jesus Christ - the Church. Thus the Church in a real sense is the spiritual Israel. This is equally clear in Romans 2: 28-29: "For he is not a real Jew who is one outwardly, nor is true circumcision something external and physical. He is a Jew who is one inwardly, and

[1] See John F. Walvoord, The Millennial Kingdom (Durham Publishing Co., Findlay, Ohio, 1959), pp. 71 f., 124.

real circumcision is a matter of the heart, spiritual and not literal." The King James Version gives a different impression by rendering "in the spirit" and "in the letter". These [wo phrases have no reference to the Holy Spirit. Neither is "in the spirit" a parallel construction to "of the heart". They refer to two ways of interpreting the Old Testament teaching about circumcision, as RSV indicates. The Greek, literally translated, reads, "circumcision (is) of heart, in spirit not letter". "In letter" means a literal interpretation of circumcision. It is done by cutting off a piece of flesh from the body, as the Jews did under the Old Testament order, to become the literal people of God. "In spirit" means a spiritual interpretation of circumcision. It is done by the Holy Spirit making a change in the heart so that we become the spiritual people of God - the true seed-the true Israel. Let no one suggest that it is wrong to interpret the Old Testament "spiritually"; the New Testament does exactly that in reinterpreting circumcision in spiritual terms and applying it to Christian experience. Our first proposition is now established: Believers are the true sons of Abraham, the true seed, the spiritual circumcision - the spiritual Israel.

II

Our second proposition is this: The New Testament takes promises which in the Old Testament were directed to literal Israel and applies them "spiritually" to the Church.

Let us use two proofs. The prophet Hosea foretells the rejection of literal Israel because of her sin. Hosea was directed by God to act out a parable to illustrate God's relationship to Israel. He was commanded to name one of his children "Lo-ruhamah", which means "not pitied". The reason for this follows: God said, "for I will no more have pity on the house of Israel" (l: 6). Another son Hosea was to name "Lo-ammi", which means "not my people". The meaning of this is, "for you are not my people and I am not your God" (1: 9). By this acted parable, Hosea was to show Israel that God had rejected her. However, Hosea foresees a restoration of the literal Israel. God will make a new covenant with Israel (2: 18) and will betroth Israel to himself forever (2: 19). "And I will have pity on Not pitied, and I will say to Not my people, 'You are my people'" (2: 23). Literal Israel which has been rejected is to be restored.

The New Testament applies the prophecy to the spiritual Israel -the Church. Speaking of this new people who consist not of the Jews only, but also of the Gentiles, Paul says, "As indeed he says in Hosea, 'Those who were not my people I will call "my people", and her who was not beloved I will call "my beloved"," (Rom. 9: 25). Again, referring to Hosea 1: 9, which we have quoted, Paul adds "And in the very place where it was said to them, You are not my people", they will be called 'sons of the living God' " (Rom. 9: 26). How can we avoid the conclusion that Paul here means to say that the promise of the restoration of literal Israel is fulfilled in the Church? A second proof. Joel, like Hosea, foresees the restoration of literal Israel. "You shall

know that I am in the midst of Israel, and that I, the Lord, am your God and there is none else. And my people shall never again be put to shame" (Joel 2: 27). Then follows the wonderful prophecy of the outpouring of the Holy Spirit upon all flesh (2: 28-29). This is clearly a promise to literal Israel, for the prophecy continues, "For behold, 111 those days and at that time, when I restore the fortunes of Judah and Jerusalem .... " (3: 1). However, on the day of Pentecost when the Holy Spirit was given to the Church, Peter, under inspiration, said, "This is what was spoken by the prophet Joel" (Acts 2: 16). A prol1llse given to literal Israel is fulfilled to spiritual Israel-the Church.

III

Our third proposition is this: The Old Testament systei!1 of animal sacrifices has forever passed away because the re3lItyChrist- has come. This is taught in the Epistle to the Hebrews. The Old Covenant, made with literal Israel, included the bloody sacrifices of bulls and goats. These, however, could not take away sins (Heb. 10: 4). They were only types and shadows of the reality embodied in the death of Christ (Heb. 10: 1). However, now that the reality has come, the shadows have passed away (Heb. 10: 2). Christ has become the Mediator of a better covenant (Heb. 8: 6). The old Mosaic covenant, with its animal sacrifices was not adequate to accomplish God's redemptive purpose. If it had been, there would have been no need for a second covenant (8: 7). However, God promised through Jeremiah (31: 31-34) a new covenant when God would write His law within the heart, when He would effect a forgiveness of sins. This is the new covenant in Christ's blood, "poured out for many for the forgiveness of sins" (Mt. 26: 28). Because this new covenant has been established, the old covenant is displaced by the new covenant. "In speaking of a new covenant, he treats the first as obsolete. And what is becoming obsolete and growing old is ready to vanish away" (Heb. 8: 13). The Old Testament order with its system of animal sacrifices, even though it still existed when Hebrews was written, had been superseded by the new covenant in Christ; and the temple order actually did pass away shortly after the writing of Hebrews when Jerusalem and the temple were destroyed in A.D. 70. The message of the entire Epistle to the Hebrews is that all of these institutions and sacrifices which pertained to the age of types and shadows have passed away, because they have been fulfilled by the realities in Christ.

IV

Our fourth proposition is this: Although the Church is the spiritual Israel, the New Testament teaches that literal Israel is yet to be saved. Paul was greatly concerned about the fate of Israel and the apparent failure of the promises of God. However, the fact that Israel rejected her Messiah and failed to come to faith does not mean that the promises of God and the Word of God have failed (Rom. 9: 6). The promises of God are fulfilled in the true (spiritual) seed of Abraham (Rom. 9: 7 ff.). The true people of God, whose salvation was foretold in Hosea 2: 23 and 1: 10, consists not of literal Israel but of those "whom he has called, not from the Jews only but also from the Gentiles" (Rom. 9: 24). Literal Israel has stumbled against the rock of offence (Rom. 9:33). Christ has brought to its fulfilment the entire intent and purpose of the Law and thereby has ended the dispensation of Law, having introduced the dispensation of righteousness by faith (Rom. 10: 4). Israel has not entered into this faith, and in disobedience and stubbornness has refused to respond to God's gracious plea (Rom. 10: 21).

However, this does not mean that God has finally cast away His people (Rom. 11: 1). There is, first of all, a remnant of literal Israel who have believed in Christ (11: 5). The rest of Israel were blinded (Il: 7). However, the purpose of their blindness is not their fall; because of their fall, salvation has come to the Gentiles (11: 11). Then Paul makes a key statement: “Now if their trespass means riches for the world, and if their failure means riches, for the Gentiles, how much more will their full inclusion mean!” (11: 12).

In this statement is embodied Paul's theology of the future salvation of Israel. If the fall of Israel has brought salvation to the Gentiles, in how much larger measure will salvation come to the Gentile world if the "fullness", i.e., full salvation of literal Israel, come in? Israel was God's chosen instrument to bring salvation to the world. This was the heart of the promise given to Abraham. He was to be the father of many nations, and in him would all families of the earth be blessed (Gen. 12: 1-3; 17: 6). Romans 4: 17-18 and Galatians 3: 8 prove that this promise is to be interpreted not only literally of Abraham's physical seed but that the deeper truth is found in the spiritual interpretation which applies it to believers in Christ - the Church. This is why Christ came into the world as an Israelite. Israel's rejection of her Messiah and her subsequent fall were no mere accident of history but the means used by God to bring salvation to the Gentiles. But this is not the last chapter of the story. The Church age as we know it is not the end. Two things must yet happen: The fullness of literal Israel must come in, and by her salvation greater riches be brought to the Gentile world.

Paul further develops this truth in the following verses. Literal Israel is still the chosen people. She is still the special object of God's care and will yet be the instrument of salvation.

This is asserted in Romans 11: 15-16. The firstfruits of Israel (the patriarchs) were holy - i.e., the objects o~ God's election and care; and the entire lump (Israel as a people) is also holy. If the root of the tree is holy, so is the entire tree. The people Israel continues to be a "holy" people-a people whom God has designated for his redemptive purpose in the world. This future purpose is Indicated in the following words: "For if their rejection means the reconciliation of the world, what will their acceptance mean but life from the dead?" (v. 15). Here is a twofold contrast: the present rejection of Israel because of unbelief is contrasted with a future receiving of Israel in belief. The other contrast is even more significant. The present rejection of unbelieving Israel means that the message of reconciliation has gone out to all the world; Israel's future restoration will mean much more than this-a state of blessedness which Paul describes by the phrase "life from the dead". The balanced structure of the sentence shows that this is a blessing which comes upon Gentile. world. The balance of the sentence is the key to its interpretation, and the following diagram illustrates the balance.

I	II
b. Present rejection of Israel.	b. Reconciliation of the world.
c. Future restoration of Israel.	b. Life from the dead

Israel is the subject of the two members in Part I ; and the Gentile world is the subject of the two members in Part H. "Life from the dead" (H b) is not a parallel member with "Israel" (I b) but with "the world" (II a). It stands in contrast with Israel (l b). "Life from the dead" does not refer to Israel's restoration but to the results of Israel's restoration in the Gentile world. Israel's future salvation will issue in a new order of blessedness and happiness for the Gentile world which is likened to the emergence of life from the dead. There remains in the future for the world an enjoyment of the reality of the life in Christ extending far beyond anything we have now experienced; and this will be accomplished through the Instrumentality of Israel's conversion. Paul does not here tell us when or how this era of blessing will occur; but we believe it wiIl take place during the Millennium.

Paul sums the entire matter up in verses 25-27. Israel is now hardened. The Gentiles are now being brought in. Finally "all Israel shall be saved". "Israel" here is literal Israel; and "all Israel" does not need to mean every single Israelite but the people as a whole. Paul does not add here the thought that through this salvation of the people Israel, a new wave of life will come to the whole world, for his concern at this point is only the destiny of Israel.

V

Our final proposition is this: This future salvation of Israel must take place on fundamentally the same terms as the salvation of the Gentiles, viz., through saving faith in Jesus Christ as her crucified Messiah. The New Testament nowhere elaborates upon how this is to take place. The words in Romans 11: 26, "The Deliverer will come from Zion, he will banish ungodliness from Jacob" do not necessarily refer to the Second Coming of Christ. This is a composite quotation from Isaiah 59: 20 and 27: 9, neither of which refers to the Messiah. So far as the passage in Romans 11 is concerned, the salvation of Israel could occur by a great evangelistic movement which would bring Israel into the Church. However, the Old Testament constantly envisages the salvation of Israel as a distinct entity. Therefore, we can only suggest that the means of Israel's conversion may actually be the Second Coming of Christ itself. God said through Zechariah: "And I will pour out on the house of David and the inhabitants of Jerusalem: a spirit of compassion and supplication, so that, when they look on him whom they have pierced, they shall mourn for him, as one mourns for an only child, and weep bitterly over him, as one weeps over a first-born" (12: 10). Apparently the appearance of the pierced Christ will convict Israel of her sinfulness.

This does not mean that Israel will be saved on any other ground than by faith in Christ. It does suggest that the means of salvation is unusual. Saul of Tarsus was brought to faith only by a special vision of the glorified Christ; yet he was saved by faith like any believer and was brought into the Christian Church. In a similar way, perhaps, it will be the appearance of the returning Christ which will be the means of convincing Israel that Jesus was actually her Messiah. If so, they will be saved by faith in Christ and in the largest sense of the word will become a part of the Church, yet as a distinct people. Perhaps during the Millennium, we shall see for the first time in human history a truly Christian nation-Israel converted and brought to faith in Jesus as her Messiah.

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ISRAEL AND THE CHURCH

by GEORGE ELDON LADD

DR. LADD, who occupies the Chair of New Testament History and Biblical Theology in Fuller Theological Seminary, Pasadena, California, is well known to readers of THE EVANGELICAL QUARTERLY. This study of Israel and the Church is closely related to other subjects on which he has already written for us, and comes within the area of his special interests. If some readers do not care for his references to the Millennium in the fourth and fifth sections of this article, they may replace that word by the Pauline "ages to come" (Eph. 2: 7) in which God will perfect that cosmic reconciliation of which the Church is His present model.

THE theological problem of the relationship of Israel to the church has received radically diverse answers. On the one hand is a type of covenantal theology which insists that the church is spiritual Israel in the most exhaustive sense of the word. Because Israel rejected her Messiah, God has rejected Israel. The Kingdom has been taken away from Israel and "given to a nation producing the fruits of it" (Matt. 21: 43). This "royal priesthood", this "holy nation", this "God's own people" is the Church (1 Pet. 2: 9). The Church is therefore the spiritual Israel, the true people of God. When the Jews in Rome rejected the gospel, Paul said, "Let it be known to you then that this salvation of God has been sent to the Gentiles; they will listen" (Acts 28: 28). Because Israel rejected her Messiah, "God's wrath has come upon them at last" (1 Thess. 2: 16). The Church is now the "Israel of God" (Gal. 6: 16). The spiritual Israel has taken the place of the literal Israel. The Old Testament promises to the literal Israel must be interpreted in terms of the spiritual blessings enjoyed by the Church. Therefore there is no need of a Millennial Kingdom. Israelites will be saved only as they believe on Christ and come into the Church.

At the opposite extreme is the dispensationalist interpretation which insists that Israel and the Church are two separate peoples which cannot be mingled and must not be confused. In fact, God has two different programmes which He is carrying out in history: one with Israel and one with the Church. God's theocratic programme with Israel was interrupted when Israel rejected Christ. God therefore turned away from Israel to accomplish His redemptive purpose in the Church. When this purpose has been fulfilled, God will resume His relations with Israel. The Millennium will see

the resumption of this theocratic purpose and Israel will be restored as a nation, in her land of Palestine, with a reconstituted monarchy, and will rule over the nations of the earth on behalf of her God. Her King will be the promised Davidic Messiah who will sit upon the literal throne of David and rule the world from Jerusalem. Israel's temple worship and priestly order of Old Testament times, including the sacrificial system, will be restored. All the promises of the Old Testament will be fulfilled in literal terms. The Millennium, in other words, will be a revival or renewal of the Old Testament order. The church age is a parenthesis in God's programme for Israel and must not be confused with it. To some dispensational theologians, one of the greatest dangers to sound Biblical interpretation is a "spiritualizing" hermeneutic which applies spiritually to the church promises which were made to Israel. In fact, a literalistic hermeneutic is sometimes made the test of orthodoxy.[1]

Perhaps, as is often the case, the Biblical solution to the problem lies between the two extremes. We would attempt to solve the problem by a series of five propositions.

I

First, in some real sense, the Church has taken the place of Israel and must be called the "spiritual" Israel. This "spiritualizing" of Israel began in the Old Testament. Paul makes this clear. Not all who are descended from Abraham *physically* are sons of Abraham *spiritually*. "Not all are children of Abraham because they are his descendants" (Rom. 9: 7). "It is not the children of the flesh who are the children of God, but the children of the promise are reckoned as descendants" (Rom. 9: 8). The physical seed is not the true seed. The literal Israel is not the spiriual Israel. The spiritual Israel, the spiritual seed, consists only of those within the physical seed who are children of promise. The Scripture limits the true spiritual seed of Abraham to one narrowing line within the physical descendants.

Not only is the spiritual seed of Abraham limited to a small group within the literal seed, it is also extended to the Church. Paul makes this clear in Romans 4: 16, 18. God had promised Abraham that his seed should be as innumerable as the stars; Paul applies this promise to the Church. This promise to Abraham's seed, says Paul, was given "not only to the adherents of the law

[1] See John F. Walvoord, *The Millennial Kingdom* (Durham Publishing Co., Findlay, Ohio, 1959), pp. 71 f., 124.

(the literal seed) but also to those who share the faith of Abraham" (the spiritual seed) (Rom. 4: 16). Therefore, "if you are Christ's, then you are Abraham's offspring, heirs according to promise" (Gal. 3: 29). Thus Abraham is "the father of us all" who have the same justifying faith which Abraham had (Rom. 4: 16). Abraham has been made "the father of all who believe without being circumcised" (Rom. 4: 11). It is impossible for language to state more clearly that Abraham's spiritual seed, his true spiritual children, are the men of faith—believers in the Lord Jesus Christ—the Church. Thus the Church in a real sense *is* the spiritual Israel.

This is equally clear in Romans 2: 28-29 : "For he is not a real Jew who is one outwardly, nor is true circumcision something external and physical. He is a Jew who is one inwardly, and real circumcision is a matter of the heart, spiritual and not literal." The King James Version gives a different impression by rendering "in the spirit" and "in the letter". These two phrases have no reference to the Holy Spirit. Neither is "in the spirit" a parallel construction to "of the heart". They refer to two ways of interpreting the Old Testament teaching about circumcision, as RSV indicates. The Greek, literally translated, reads, "circumcision (is) of heart, in spirit not letter". "In letter" means a literal interpretation of circumcision. It is done by cutting off a piece of flesh from the body, as the Jews did under the Old Testament order, to become the literal people of God. "In spirit" means a spiritual interpretation of circumcision. It is done by the Holy Spirit making a change in the heart so that we become the spiritual people of God—the true seed—the true Israel. Let no one suggest that it is wrong to interpret the Old Testament "spiritually" ; the New Testament does exactly that in reinterpreting circumcision in spiritual terms and applying it to Christian experience. Our first proposition is now established : Believers are the true sons of Abraham, the true seed, the spiritual circumcision—the spiritual Israel.

II

Our second proposition is this : The New Testament takes promises which in the Old Testament were directed to literal Israel and applies them "spiritually" to the Church.

Let us use two proofs. The prophet Hosea foretells the rejection of literal Israel because of her sin. Hosea was directed by God to act out a parable to illustrate God's relationship to Israel. He was commanded to name one of his children "Lo-ruhamah", which means "not pitied". The reason for this follows : God said, "for I will no more have pity on the house of Israel" (1: 6). Another son Hosea was to name "Lo-ammi", which means "not my people". The meaning of this is, "for you are not my people and I am not your God" (1: 9). By this acted parable, Hosea was to show Israel that God had rejected her. However, Hosea foresees a restoration of the literal Israel. God will make a new covenant with Israel (2: 18) and will betroth Israel to himself forever (2: 19). "And I will have pity on Not pitied, and I will say to Not my people, 'You are my people' " (2: 23). Literal Israel which has been rejected is to be restored.

The New Testament applies the prophecy to the spiritual Israel —the Church. Speaking of this new people who consist not of the Jews only, but also of the Gentiles, Paul says, "As indeed he says in Hosea, 'Those who were not my people I will call "my people", and her who was not beloved I will call "my beloved" ' " (Rom. 9: 25). Again, referring to Hosea 1: 9, which we have quoted, Paul adds, "And in the very place where it was said to them, 'You are not my people', they will be called 'sons of the living God' " (Rom. 9: 26). How can we avoid the conclusion that Paul here means to say that the promise of the restoration of literal Israel is fulfilled in the Church ?

A second proof. Joel, like Hosea, foresees the restoration of literal Israel. "You shall know that I am in the midst of Israel, and that I, the Lord, am your God and there is none else. And my people shall never again be put to shame" (Joel 2: 27). Then follows the wonderful prophecy of the outpouring of the Holy Spirit upon all flesh (2: 28-29). This is clearly a promise to literal Israel, for the prophecy continues, "For behold, in those days and at that time, when I restore the fortunes of Judah and Jerusalem. . . ." (3: 1).

However, on the day of Pentecost when the Holy Spirit was given to the Church, Peter, under inspiration, said, "This is what was spoken by the prophet Joel" (Acts 2: 16). A promise given to literal Israel is fulfilled to spiritual Israel—the Church.

III

Our third proposition is this : The Old Testament system of animal sacrifices has forever passed away because the reality—Christ—has come. This is taught in the Epistle to the Hebrews. The Old Covenant, made with literal Israel, included the bloody sacrifices of bulls and goats. These, however, could not take away sins (Heb. 10: 4). They were only types and shadows of the reality embodied in the death of Christ (Heb. 10: 1). However, now that the reality has come, the shadows have passed away (Heb. 10: 2). Christ has become the Mediator of a better covenant (Heb. 8: 6). The old Mosaic covenant, with its animal sacrifices,

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Our fourth proposition is this: Although the Church is the spiritual Israel, the New Testament teaches that literal Israel is yet to be saved. Paul was greatly concerned about the fate of Israel and the apparent failure of the promises of God. However, the fact that Israel rejected her Messiah and failed to come to faith does not mean that the promises of God and the Word of God have failed (Rom. 9: 6). The promises of God are fulfilled in the true (spiritual) seed of Abraham (Rom. 9: 7 ff.). The true people of God, whose salvation was foretold in Hosea 2: 23 and 1: 10, consists not of literal Israel but of those "whom he has called, not from the Jews only but also from the Gentiles" (Rom. 9: 24). Literal Israel has stumbled against the rock of offence (Rom. 9: 33). Christ has brought to its fulfilment the entire intent and purpose of the Law and thereby has ended the dispensation of Law, having introduced the dispensation of righteousness by faith (Rom. 10: 4). Israel has not entered into this faith, and in disobedience and stubbornness has refused to respond to God's gracious plea (Rom. 10: 21).

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I	II
a. Present rejection of Israel.	a. Reconciliation of the world.
b. Future restoration of Israel.	b. Life from the dead.

Israel is the subject of the two members in Part I ; and the Gentile world is the subject of the two members in Part II. "Life from the dead" (II b) is not a parallel member with "Israel" (I b) but with "the world" (II a). It stands in *contrast* with Israel (I b). "Life from the dead" does not refer to Israel's restoration but to the results of Israel's restoration in the Gentile world. Israel's future salvation will issue in a new order of blessedness and happiness for the Gentile world which is likened to the emergence of life from the dead. There remains in the future for the world an enjoyment of the reality of the life in Christ extending far beyond anything we have now experienced ; and this will be accomplished through the instrumentality of Israel's conversion. Paul does not here tell us when or how this era of blessing will occur ; but we believe it will take place during the Millennium.

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V

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